

The game ends when all of one player's pits are empty. The other player claims the remaining seeds for their store, and the winner is the one with the most seeds. More information about Mancala and its variants can be found at <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mancala>.

The Program in Action

When you run *mancala.py*, the output will look like this:

```
Mancala, by Al Sweigart al@inventwithpython.com
--snip--

+-----+-----+<<<<<Player 2-----+-----+-----+
2      |G      |H      |I      |J      |K      |L      |      1
      |  4      |  4      |  4      |  4      |  4      |  4      |
S      |      |      |      |      |      |      |      S
T  0  +-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+  0  T
O      |A      |B      |C      |D      |E      |F      |      O
R      |  4      |  4      |  4      |  4      |  4      |  4      |      R
E      |      |      |      |      |      |      |      E
+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+
+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+
+-----+-----+<<<<<Player 1->>>>>-----+-----+-----+

Player 1, choose move: A-F (or QUIT)
> f

+-----+-----+<<<<<Player 2-----+-----+-----+
2      |G      |H      |I      |J      |K      |L      |      1
      |  4      |  4      |  4      |  5      |  5      |  5      |
S      |      |      |      |      |      |      |      S
T  0  +-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+  1  T
O      |A      |B      |C      |D      |E      |F      |      O
R      |  4      |  4      |  4      |  4      |  4      |  0      |      R
E      |      |      |      |      |      |      |      E
+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+
+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+
+-----+-----+<<<<<Player 1->>>>>-----+-----+-----+
Player 2, choose move: G-L (or QUIT)
--snip--
```

How It Works

Mancala uses ASCII art to display the board. Notice that each pocket needs to have not only the number of seeds in it but a label as well. To avoid confusion, the labels use the letters *A* through *L* so they won't be mistaken for the number of seeds in each pocket. The dictionaries `NEXT_PIT` and `OPPOSITE_PIT` map the letter of one pocket to the letter of the pit next to or opposite it, respectively. This lets the expression `NEXT_PIT['A']` evaluate to `'B'` and the expression `OPPOSITE_PIT['A']` evaluate to `'G'`. Pay attention to how the code uses these dictionaries. Without them, our Mancala program would require long series of `if` and `elif` statements to carry out the same game steps.